

# The Regional Office of Astronomy for Development in the Arab World

# (AW-ROAD)

**Hosted by:**

**The Arab Union for Astronomy & Space Science (AUASS)**

**The Hashemite Kingdom of Jordan**

**August 2018**

# Background

Astronomy, Astrophysics and Space Sciences (AASS) play an effective role in Sciences, Technology and Community Development. Unfortunately, a small percentage of this knowledge is actually used in teaching at schools, universities and other academic institutions in Arab countries. The challenge is to provide effective professional development for AASS educators and researchers at all levels, from elementary school to university. There is an urgent need for a better communication channels among Arab astronomers and space scientists nowadays. In this respect, the best choice is to identify in the vast cultural heritage of the Arab basin, particularly in astronom . Building modern and good observatories, planetariums and research centers in the region jointly by Arab astronomers and space scientists is essential and will be an excellent step towards developing AASS.

The Arab Union of Astronomy and Space Science (AUASS) has been rather active in proposing projects and submitting a proposal to host a regional office in Arab World. IAU found the AUASS proposal rather strong and justified since it represents all of Arab countries. During the 11th Arab Conference on Astronomy and Space Science, which was held in Sharjah (United Arab Emirates) between the 5th and 8th of December 2014 under the patronage of Sheikh Sultan Bin Mohammed Al-Qasemi, the ruler Of Sharjah, the AUASS had discussed this issue with Mr. Kevin Govender (from the OAD) with the presence of the high council members of AUASS. Finally, they took a resolution of selecting the Hashemite Kingdom of Jordan to Host the IAU Office of Astronomy for Development in the Arab region. An agreement was signed in this regard at the IAU's General Assembly in Honolulu in August 2015.

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# Inauguration

The Arab Regional Office of Astronomy for Development (Arab-ROAD) and the Arabic Language Expertise Center (Arab-LOAD) had officially joined the IAU-Office of Astronomy for Development (OAD) network. The inauguration took place in Amman, the Capital of Jordan, on the 2nd and 3rd of December 2015.

The inauguration was attended by the IAU General Secretary (Prof. Piero Benvenuti), the Director of the OAD (Mr. Kevin Govender), representatives of the host institution and from several Arab states in the region. Dr. Awni Al-Khasawneh, the General Secretary of the Arab Union for Astronomy and Space Sciences (AUASS), and the General Director of the Royal Jordanian Geographic Centre (RJGC), had delivered a welcome address. Prof. Hamid Al-Naimiy, President of the AUASS and Chancellor of the University of Sharjah, had read a statement, and Prof. Dia Eddin Arafa, President of Al al-Bayt University (AABU), had given the opening address.

The meeting also included individual sessions focusing on Astronomy for Development, astronomical projects and capacity building in the Arab world, in addition to a round table discussion. A meeting of the Regional Office's Steering Committee had also convened during this time.

The Arab Regional Office (Arab-ROAD) and Arabic Language Expertise Center (Arabic-LOAD) is thus hosted by the Arab Union for Astronomy and Space Sciences (AUASS) which is currently located at the Royal Jordanian Geographical Centre (RJGC) in Amman, Jordan. In addition the RJGC hosts the Regional Centre for Space Science and Technology Education which is affiliated to the United Nations Office for Outer Space Affairs (UNOOSA).




Dr Awni Al-Khasawneh stated that “The approval of IAU regional office, which has been decided last August during the IAU General Assembly, is an important step for our Arab countries to maintain good scientific relations with the international astronomical community. It will provide opportunities for our young astronomers and students to be trained and participate in many international conferences.”

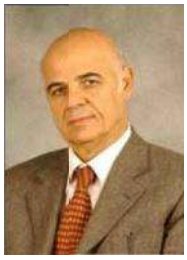


*Discussions of the Steering Committee of the AW-ROAD*



*A group picture of participants in the Inauguration Ceremony*

# The Steering Committee



**Hamid M.K. Al-Naimiy**
**UAE**



**Awni Al-Khasawneh**
**Jordan**



**Haik Harutyunian**
**Armenia**



**Kevin Govender**
**South Africa**



**Jamal Mimouni**
**Algeria**



**Suleiman Baraka**
**Palestine**



**Shawqi Al- Dallal**
**Bahrain**



**Areg Mickaelian**
**Armenia**



**Roger Hajjar**
**Lebanon**



**Saleh Al-shedhani**
**Oman**



*AUASS's President with the IAU General Secretary*



*Members of the OAD Regional Offices*

# Some of the Activities of the AW-ROAD

Since its official inauguration, the AW-ROAD has been organizing local and regional activities in collaboration with the Arab Union for Astronomy and Space Science (AUASS), the Jordanian Astronomical Society (JAS), the Syrian Astronomical Society (SAS), the Sharjah Center for Astronomy and Space Science (SCASS), the Oman Astronomical Society (OAS), the Sirius Astronomical Association (Algeria), Ibn al-Haytham Association for Science and Astronomy (Algeria), and the Tunisian Astronomical Society.

## Weekly Activities at the JAS Cultural Forum

**Weekly Lectures at the JAS Cultural Forum (every Thursday evening, located at the AUASS Head Office in Amman) are organized on various topics related to astronomy, astrophysics and space science and its applications.**

*** Weekly lectures in the first half of 2018:**

| Date | Lecture | Lecturer/ Supervisor |
|---|---|---|
| 04-01-2018 | When the Night Sky Spoke Arabic | Prof. Abulqader Abed |
| 11-01-2018 | The Multiverse Scenarios | Dr. Ammar Sakaji |
| 18-01-2018 | Film Screening about the HST | Eng. Khaled Tell |
| 25-01-2018 | Open Session & Astronomy Contest | Ms. Basma Diab |
| 01-02-2018 | Conceptions of the Universe: from Aristotle to Kaluza | Prof. Hisham Ghassib |
| 08-02-2018 | Can Science Save the Dead Sea ? | Prof. Najib Abu Karaki |
| 15-02-2018 | The Space-Related Causes of Climate Change | Dr. Hanna A. Sabat |
| 22-02-2018 | Some Riddles in Astrophysics and Cosmology | Dr. Ammar Sakaji |
| 01-03-2018 | The Falcon Heavy Rocket | Mr. Adli Halabi |
| 08-03-2018 | Fukushima : Seven Years after the | Dr. Ismael Attiyat |

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|---|---|---|
| | **Catastrophe** | |
| **15-03-2018** | **An Introduction to Particle Physics** | **Dr. Qays al-Omari** |
| **29-03-2018** | **Some Recent Developments in Astrobiology** | **Dr. Sohan Jheeta** |
| **12-04-2018** | **Condensed Matter: from Bose-Einstein Condensates to Neutron Stars** | **Dr. Asaad Sakhel** |
| **19-04-2018** | **If the Sun Disappeared** | **Ms. Dalal Lala** |
| **26-04-2018** | **A Brief History of Stephen Hawking** | **Dr. Hanna a. Sabat** |
| **10-05-2018** | **Observational Instruments and Astrophotography** | **Mr. Mohammad Rihan** |
| **28-06-2018** | **Space Travel** | **Dr. Ammar Sakaji** |









*Dr. Ahmed Farag Ali, Theoretical Physicist from Benha University (Egypt), delivered a lecture about the Big Bang Singularity. At Princess Sumayya Univerity (PSUT), Amman, November 2017*